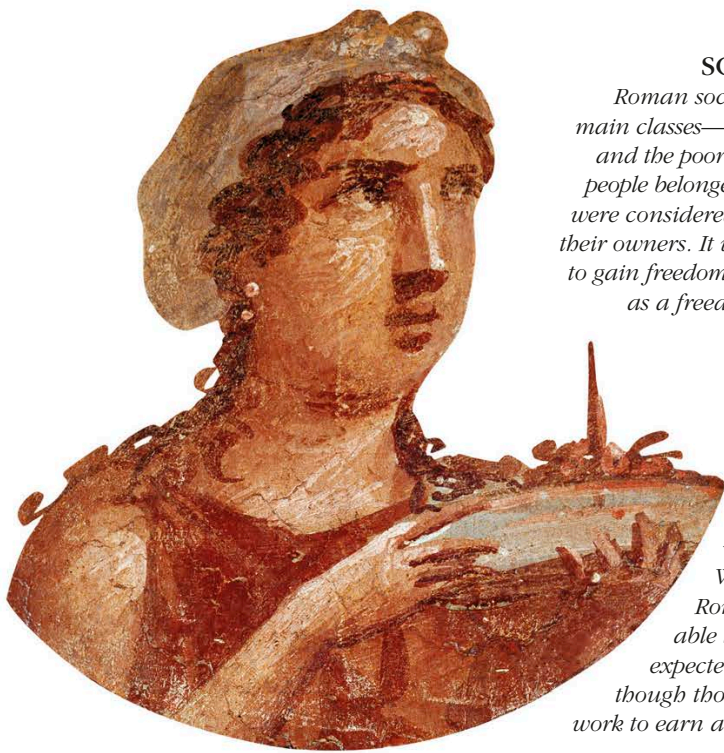




SOCIAL CLASSES ►

Roman society was split into two main classes—the wealthy patricians and the poorer plebeians. Enslaved people belonged to neither class and were considered to be the property of their owners. It was, however, possible to gain freedom from slavery and live as a freedman or freedwoman.



An enslaved person serves a drink to his enslaver.

◀ WOMEN IN ROMAN SOCIETY

Women had very few rights in the Roman Empire and were generally not able to take part in political life. They were expected to raise families and run households, though those from poor backgrounds also had to work to earn an income.



◀ PUBLIC BATHS

Every Roman town had a public bathhouse, which was not just a place to wash and relax but also to meet up with friends. Hot pools and steam rooms were usually heated by an underfloor heating system from a furnace but the Roman Baths in the city of Bath, England, were built above natural hot springs.



◀ GLADIATORS

Bloodthirsty battles between trained fighters called gladiators were popular in ancient Rome. Spectators would crowd amphitheaters to watch the fights, which were often to the death. Gladiators were usually enslaved people or prisoners who had been condemned to death, though some became major celebrities.

The grill on the bronze gladiator helmet protects the face.

ROMAN GODS

Before Christianity became the main religion of the empire in the 4th century CE, the Romans worshipped many gods and goddesses. Each god watched over a different aspect of life. The Romans built temples to the main gods, such as Jupiter (the god of the sky), where animal sacrifices were sometimes performed.

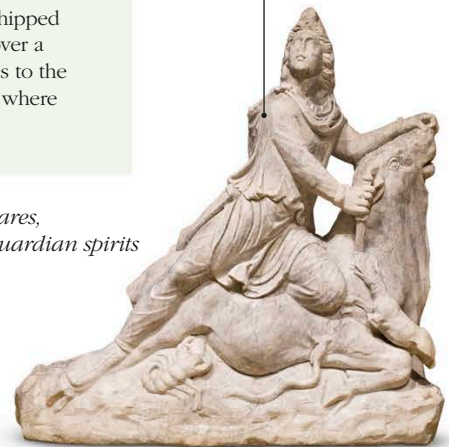


JUPITER



ALTAR TO LARES AUGUSTI

Lares, guardian spirits



Mithras, a sun god

MITHRAS SLAYING THE BULL